

Practicing Radical Acceptance Step by Step

- ☐ Observe that you are questioning or fighting reality (“It shouldn’t be this way”).
- ☐ Remind yourself that the unpleasant reality is just as it is and cannot be changed (“This is what happened”).
- ☐ Remind yourself that there are causes for the reality. Acknowledge that some sort of history led up to this very moment. Consider how people’s lives have been shaped by a series of factors. Notice that given these causal factors and how history led up to this moment, this reality had to occur just this way (“This is how things happened”).
- ☐ Practice accepting with the whole self (mind, body, and spirit). Be creative in finding ways to involve your whole self. Use accepting self-talk—but also consider using relaxation; mindfulness of your breath; half-smiling and willing hands while thinking about what feels unacceptable; prayer; going to a place that helps bring you to acceptance; or imagery.
- ☐ Practice opposite action. List all the behaviors you would do if you did accept the facts. Then act as if you have already accepted the facts. Engage in the behaviors that you would do if you really had accepted.
- ☐ Cope ahead with events that seem unacceptable. Imagine (in your mind’s eye) believing what you don’t want to accept. Rehearse in your mind what you would do if you accepted what seems unacceptable.
- ☐ Attend to body sensations as you think about what you need to accept.
- ☐ Allow disappointment, sadness, or grief to arise within you.
- ☐ Acknowledge that life can be worth living even when there is pain.
- ☐ Do pros and cons if you find yourself resisting practicing acceptance.